separate entity that would perpetuate the idea of the “right of return.” The only country in the United Nations that could have intervened was the United States. The question is, Why didn’t it?

The United States’ vote on the establishment of the State of Israel was a last-minute miracle; a Jewish friend of President Truman’s succeeded in influencing him, against the advice of the State Department, Secretary of State Marshall, and others who argued that a Jewish state in the Middle East would not survive. When the proposal to establish UNRWA was discussed in the United Nations, the Americans saw no reason to object to it, especially given the continued American dependency on Saudi oil, as well as the United States’ alliance with Britain, whose imperial considerations dictated support for the Arabs rather than the State of Israel.

In addition, the truth is that nowhere is there even a hint that there was any Israeli initiative (or that one was even considered) to persuade the United States to stop the establishment of UNRWA and/or influence the definition of Palestinian refugeehood. This was because it was convenient for Israel for foreign money to free it from the heavy burden involved in providing for Palestinian refugees.

We have already seen that international treatment of the refugee problem began in 1948, while the War of Independence was being waged in full force on all fronts. On the American side, the parties dealing with this issue were the State Department and President Truman’s representative to the Conciliation Commission established by the UN, Mark Ethridge—a personal friend of Truman’s who corresponded with him directly and who supported the views of Count Bernadotte, who displayed a hostile attitude toward Israel. The US was one of the first to come out in support of UN General Assembly Resolution 194, which was adopted on December 11, 1948, and whose Article 11 recognized and established the “right of return.” This resolution has since become a major stumbling block to resolving the Arab-Israeli conflict.

The first Israeli concession on the return of refugees to the State of Israel was made in March 1949, the result of pressure by Ethridge, Secretary of State Acheson, and President Truman. Israel’s willingness in principle to make concessions was never translated into action because of the US demand that the Israeli government absorb a quarter of all of the refugees (this figure was attributed to President Truman himself). As mentioned earlier, in late May 1949, President Truman wrote a very